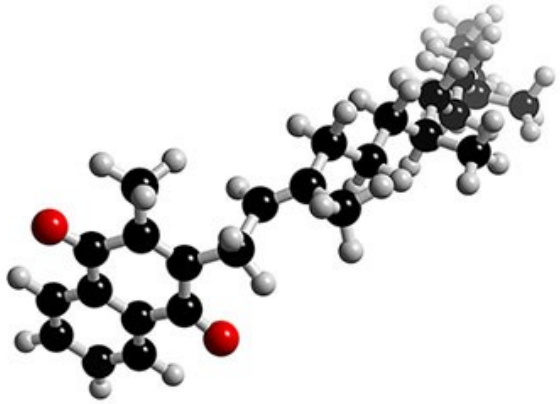
Vitamin K is biologically involved in the appropriate function of clotting factors II, VII, IX, and X. It is a fat-soluble substance found primarily in green, leafy vegetables. It may be administered orally, intramuscularly, or intravenously.

The onset of effect is delayed by about 6 hours and is complete in about 24 hours if using it to treat prothrombin (factor II) depression from warfarin or vitamin K deficiency. Intravenous administration should be performed slowly as rapid administration can result in dyspnea, chest pain, and even death.

Vitamin K deficiency frequently occurs in hospitalized and critically-ill patients as a result of poor diet, parenteral nutrition, multiple antibiotic therapy (a significant source of vitamin K is that produced by bacteria normally found in the gastrointestinal tract), surgery, and uremia.



3D model of a molecule of vitamin K

Katzung BG, Masters, SB, & Trevor AJ. Basic and Clinical Pharmacology. 11th ed. New York: McGraw-Hill; 2009: 600.

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